The PLUG Check

Plug in, blend, or unplug? Four questions to ask before the devices come out.

When laptops live on a cart instead of in backpacks, every use is a choice. Run a lesson through **P-L-U-G** to decide when the tech is worth it and when paper, talk, or hands-on work will teach it better.

P
Purpose
Start with the learning goal, not the tool. If you can only describe the lesson by naming an app, the goal is not clear yet.

L
Lift
Ask what the tech adds. Does it let students do something new, or only make the same task faster or neater?

U
Universal
Check that everyone can get to it: absent students, students with no device at home, students who need supports.

G
Go time
Count the setup minutes. Passing out, logging in, and putting back can take 10 minutes of a class.

Follow the flowchart

Planning a lesson? Start here.

P — PURPOSE
Can you name the learning goal without naming a tool?

- Not yet → Write the goal first: "Students will be able to..." Then keep going.
- Yes ↓

L — LIFT
What does the tech add to the learning?

- Nothing new → **TECH ADDS NOTHING** — **Unplug**: Teach it off-screen. Also unplug if U and G are both a flat no.
- Something new, or speed and polish ↓

U — UNIVERSAL
Can every student get to it and through it?

- No, or sort of → Plan a paper path or a backup, then keep going.

G — GO TIME
Is the learning worth the setup minutes?

- No, or sort of → Batch the device time or run it as a station.

THREE STRONG YESES
Plug in
The tech adds something new, everyone can use it, and the minutes are worth it.

EVERYTHING ELSE
Blend
Most lessons land here. Start off-screen, then plug in for the part where the tech helps.

Inspired by Mary Mitchelson, "Adapting Instruction as 1:1 Technology Access Shrinks," Edutopia, November 10, 2026.

Try it with your lesson

Check one box in each row. Most lessons land on Blend.

Lesson or activity: _____ **Date:** _____

	ASK YOURSELF	CHECK ONE	MY NOTES
P	**Purpose** Can I name the learning goal without naming a tool?	☐ Yes, the goal is clear ☐ Not yet. Write it in the notes first	
L	**Lift** What does the tech add to the learning?	☐ Something new ☐ Speed or polish ☐ Nothing new	
U	**Universal** Can every student get to it and through it?	☐ Yes, everyone ☐ Yes, with a backup ☐ Not as planned	
G	**Go time** Is the learning worth the setup minutes?	☐ Yes ☐ Yes, if I batch it ☐ Not as planned	

My call: ☐ Plug in ☐ Blend ☐ Unplug One thing I will change: _____

Plug in on purpose

- Tell students why the devices are out today.
- Teach the skill, not just the app: formatting a paper, finding a saved file, using a spreadsheet.
- Think past laptops: robots, drones, microscopes.

Add your own:

_____

Blend

- Plan on paper, publish on screen.
- Pair each online task with a print path for students who are out.
- Batch device time, or run laptops as one station.
- Offer choices: poster, model, interview, slides.

Add your own:

_____

Unplug well

- Gallery walks, centers, and exhibits that get students moving and talking.
- Draft by hand so thinking shows on the page.
- Go outside, invite an expert, or read to another class.

Add your own:

_____

Why these four questions

Purpose. Backward design starts with what students should understand, then picks the activity (Wiggins & McTighe, 2005). TPACK adds that good tech use depends on its fit with the content and the teaching (Mishra & Koehler, 2006).

Lift. SAMR, PICRAT, and Triple E all separate tech that replaces a task from tech that changes what students can do. In PISA data, moderate school computer use went with better results than rare use, and very frequent use with worse (OECD, 2015). For reading, a meta-analysis found a small comprehension edge for paper (Delgado et al., 2018).

Universal. Universal Design for Learning calls for more than one way in and more than one way to show learning (CAST, 2024). 17% of U.S. teens said they often or sometimes could not finish homework for lack of a reliable computer or internet (Pew Research Center, 2018).

Go time. Laptop-cart transitions can cost up to 10 minutes of a class (Mitchelson, 2026). Used daily, that is close to one class period a week, so save the cart for work that needs most of the block.

Sources: Anderson & Perrin (2018), *Nearly one-in-five teens can't always finish their homework because of the digital divide*, Pew Research Center · CAST (2024), *UDL Guidelines 3.0* · Delgado, Vargas, Ackerman & Salmerón (2018), *Educational Research Review, 25* · Kimmons, Graham & West (2020), *CITE Journal, 20*(1) · Kolb (2017), *Learning First, Technology Second* · Mishra & Koehler (2006), *Teachers College Record, 108*(6) · Mitchelson (2026), "Adapting Instruction as 1:1 Technology Access Shrinks," *Edutopia* · OECD (2015), *Students, Computers and Learning* · Puentedura (2006), SAMR · Wiggins & McTighe (2005), *Understanding by Design*. PLUG is a planning habit built on this research; it has not been tested as a program on its own.